

LOCAL NEWS OCTOBER 3, 2008

LIBRARY COLUMN: Library computer use getting more fair

George Williams

A big change will be happening at all seven libraries of the Latah County Library District in the next month or so for computer users. If you want to use a public computer at any of the LCLD libraries, you will have to show your library card. Here's why.

The LCLD owns 35 computers that are available for public use. Up until now we have been allocating and scheduling the public use of these computers by means of a quaint sheet-of-paper-on-a-clipboard system. Needless to say, this hasn't been ideal. For one thing, it's a difficult system for patrons to understand. A new patron coming into the library usually needs to spend several minutes in conversation with a staff member just to have the system explained to them.

Secondly, it's a very easy system for patrons to abuse. In the Moscow Public Library, for example, where the computers are spread out in different parts of the building and staff cannot always monitor them, it's not unusual for patrons to "camp out" at a computer for a couple of hours while other patrons wait for a computer because they don't want to confront the camper or interrupt busy library staff at the circulation desk.

Thirdly, conflict is a common occurrence. It's not unusual for two patrons to argue over what the correct time is or who was signed up first or whose watch has the current and correct time. Library staff spend a lot of time acting as computer conflict resolution managers as opposed to helping patrons in more

productive ways.

To help resolve these problems, beginning in the second half of October or the first half of November, depending on which library you go to, the district will be installing Envisionware's PC Reservation software on the public access computers at all seven of the public libraries in Latah County to replace our current clipboard system.

The new system will be pretty simple. If you walk into one of our libraries and a computer is available, you'll just sit down at the computer, type in your library card number and your last name, and PC Reservation will log you in to that computer for a timed computer session. If no computers are available you will be able to go to a PC Reservation sign-up station or to a library staff member to make an appointment on the next available computer. The time limits on computers will vary based on the rules that each library has in place, but the big advantage to everyone is that when the time runs out on a computer session, the computer will automatically log the user off. This will make the amount of time that one person can spend on a computer the same for every user at the library. Instead of having a few patrons camped out on the same computer for twice as long as they're allowed, everyone will have a fair and equal amount of time available to them on a library computer.

So, if you regularly use a public computer at one of the Latah County Library District libraries and you already have a library card, remember to bring it with you when you come to the library, because you won't be able to use a computer without one starting in just a couple of weeks. And if you use a computer but don't have a library card yet, be sure to get one. Any staff member at any of the seven Latah County libraries can help you with that.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

